

The short submissions

What each one is for, what to include, and what a good one looks like

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Four short pieces of writing in Michaelmas Term, worth 15% between them, each one feeding the next. Word limits carry a 10% tolerance either way; outside that range costs up to 5 marks. Within a piece, split the words however is useful — if one idea deserves 250 and another 80, fine.

Each one is submitted to Turnitin in our Blackboard theme area by **Tuesday 5pm** before the workshop, with the School Assignment Submission Form as the first page, and presented briefly in the workshop from a few slides uploaded to the group OneDrive folder by 8:40 that morning.

Before you write anything

Take an hour or two to read and think: look back at essays you have written, syllabi from classes you liked. Skim abstracts, introductions and conclusions — “future research should...” is a gift.

1. Three potential research questions

2.5% · 400–500 words total · due Tuesday 6 October, 5pm · presented in workshop 2 (8 Oct)

Three brief outlines of questions that could each become your project. For each:

- **The outcome of interest** — your dependent variable, in one plain sentence. What varies, across what units?
- **A possible explanation** — the independent variable you suspect matters.
- **Why it matters** — socially and/or to scholars. Who cares, and why should they?
- **What it builds on** — ideally a paper or two you know of that asked something close, and how yours would extend, test differently or add a nuance.

Indicate an order of preference. It is fine to develop one idea more and sketch the others.

Presentation: one slide per question, five minutes total, twelve minutes with feedback. Say the thoughts out loud — do not paste in your document.

What a good one looks like. Each question has a comparison built in (“does X make Y more likely, across...” rather than “how did Y happen in country Z”), names the units you would compare, and is narrow enough that you can imagine the data or cases in your hands. **What a weak one looks like.** A topic rather than a question (“censorship in China”), a historical narrative, or a question so big it is a PhD.

2. Final research question

2.5% · 500 words · due Tuesday 20 October, 5pm · presented in workshop 3 (22 Oct)

One question, developed on the basis of the feedback you got:

- the outcome of interest, defined precisely enough that a parent or friend with no political science could understand it;
- its significance;
- its place in the literature — what is known, what is not;
- the key explanation or independent variable, and the mechanism connecting the two;
- what your project would contribute;
- feasibility: what data or cases, and whether you can actually get them.

“Final” means *nearly* final — there will be tweaking after this — but pick one direction: at most “1.5 ideas”, two versions of the same question.

Presentation: as before, plus **one slide of specific questions for the group**. What are you unsure about? What do you need help thinking through? Be concrete.

3. Annotated bibliography

5% · 500 words · due Tuesday 3 November, 5pm · used in workshop 4 (5 Nov)

The key academic research on your question and on your dependent variable. For each item (four to six is plenty in 500 words): what it asks, its main explanation, its method, how it relates to your project, and the strength or limitation you will build on. The important question is whether and how *your* explanation extends or amends theirs.

Two suggestions:

- **Search on X and Y separately.** What do scholars think causes your Y? What effects does your X have elsewhere? Your combination is new; your X and your Y separately almost certainly are not. Someone has done something similar in another region, or thirty years ago, or with television instead of TikTok — find them and use them as a blueprint.
- **Read smart and read up.** You need not read every word of everything, but you must get the contours. Be guided by prominent work in well-known outlets; if your main source is in an obscure journal you have never heard of, you are probably missing better work. Google Scholar, the Annual Review of Political Science, Oxford encyclopedias, and the literature reviews inside good articles are your friends.

You should be reading far more broadly than what fits in 500 words.

In workshop 4 we do something different: I send each of you a classmate’s final research question; you fill in the [research design worksheet](#) about *their* project and explain it back to them and the group. Bring your own list of open questions too.

4. Three potential methodologies

5% · 500 words · due Tuesday 17 November, 5pm · presented in workshop 5 (19 Nov)

Three ways you could answer your question. For each: the method itself; why it suits *this* question; feasibility, including data sources and whether they exist and are accessible; and how you would implement it. Argue for a preference if you have one.

Some of what I will ask: What is your unit of observation? How is the outcome measured — and does it vary? Is the independent variable measured *before* the outcome changes? What else could explain the pattern, and what will you do about it? Do you have enough cases (or a large enough N)? If the plan is quantitative: what is the simplest model that answers the question? (Usually a regression. You do not need anything fancier.) If qualitative: what is the comparison, and what would you expect to see if you were wrong?

Presentation: a slide per approach. Data sources with names, not “I will find data”.

Then: the research proposal

Compulsory but ungraded · 1,500 words · due Friday 11 December, 5pm

Introduction (topic, social and scholarly significance) · literature review · the variation to be explained · the main posited explanation(s) · the methodological strategy, with data. You get detailed written feedback, and it is the document you work from over the break. Start data collection before Christmas if you possibly can.